

MALL ENTREPRENEUR

■ By Nandini Vaish

It's 7.30 a.m. and cleaning operations are underway at the Great India Place (GIP) mall in Noida. A dozen uniformed houseboys are darting across the floor with mops while Yanni blares in the background. Some are navigating the floors with bright-yellow cleaning machines. There is not a moment to lose. The mall opens at 11 and the 150-odd housekeeping staff have to finish tidying up the 7 lakh-sq ft mall by 10. Forty-eight-year-old Sarita Sarvria is quietly monitoring the progress of her team. She is the managing director of Express Housekeeping, which provides professional cleaning services to malls.

Business, Sarvria says, has never been better. She started her company in 1988 with the Mauve n Pink boutique in Delhi's Khan Market as her first client. Once a housekeeper with the Taj Group of Hotels, she now manages more than 20 malls and has a staff of 10,000. Her company, which has touched annual revenues of Rs 50 crore, could be the largest entrepreneur-driven housekeeping service in the country.

Forget Internet startups and IT companies. Some of the biggest areas of opportunity for aspiring entrepreneurs are the same mundane ventures that have been around for ages. An average 1 lakh-sq ft mall needs 15-20 such vendors. Besides architecture and design, there are opportunities in security, air-conditioning, plumbing and janitorial services, nurseries, grooming schools, food courts, window-pane cleaning, parking management, decoration, and more. Today, these old businesses have found a new catalyst for their growth—the mall boom.

At present, about 100 malls are operational in India covering an area of 1.9 crore sq ft. A Citi-AT Kearney report estimates another 300 malls would be constructed in the country by 2010. If a single 1 lakh-sq ft mall rakes in about Rs 6 lakh worth of business for Sarvria, it could mean an opportunity of around



Mriganka Gupta, 62 & Bhavana Banga, 35

Sri Sanskar School of Etiquette and Career Development

Specialisation: Communication training and personal grooming

Number of employees: 20

Revenues: Not available

THEN: Founded by the mother-daughter duo in 2005, the school at Noida started with the training of personnel in BPOs and the hospitality sector.

NOW: Today they have takers in several malls and train staff from housekeeping to management. Says Banga, "People need to know how soft skills get them better jobs."

